

Release of fuel may ease prices

U.S. and other G-7 nations will provide 100 million barrels, including diesel.

By COLLIN BINKLEY AND JOHN LEICESTER

The Group of 7 industrial nations said Friday that they plan to release 100 million barrels of oil and fuel products in the coming weeks, starting with “substantial” amounts of diesel after the fuel recently hit record-high prices in the United States.

President Trump said the diesel release would happen “immediately,” echoing a G-7 statement that a “frontloaded substantial release” of diesel would begin within the next 20 days with the rest over four months.

Trump and his Republican Party face pressure to address surging prices ahead of the Nov. 3 midterm elections, and the president announced the action Friday on social media. His approval ratings on the economy hit a new low, according to an AP-NORC poll, as the Iran war and his trade battles have increased U.S. prices for oil and other goods.

Gas prices in the U.S. and abroad have soared during the eight-month war, a cost Trump has repeatedly said is worth it for making sure Iran does not develop nuclear weapons.

The surging price of diesel, which is crucial for transportation, farming and industry, has had broad effects across the economy. The national average for a gallon of diesel in the U.S. was \$6.37 on Friday, according to AAA, after hitting a record \$6.52 on Sept. 22. Diesel prices have hit records in Europe too.

The release of diesel in Europe might mean fewer exports of diesel from the U.S., which could lower prices by 25 to 50 cents per gallon after a few weeks, said Michael Lynch, distinguished fellow at Energy [See Fuel, A12]



RYAN JENKINSON Getty Images



GINA FERAZZI Los Angeles Times

THE SURGING price of diesel is affecting the U.S. and Europe. A refinery Friday in Ellesmere Port, England, top, and a gas station in Riverside last month, above.

Long-awaited report details failures in fires

Independent inquiry finds a web of errors contributed to Eaton, Palisades disasters.

By NOAH HAGGERTY, GRACE TOOHEY, TERRY CASTLEMAN AND ALENE TCHEKMEDYIAN

In the aftermath of the Eaton and Palisades fires, which killed 31 people and destroyed more than 16,000 structures, survivors have been frustrated by a series of official investigations that have glossed over or downplayed failures on the part of Los Angeles city and county agencies.

Now, a long-awaited independent investigation commissioned by Gov. Gavin Newsom provides the most frank and in-depth review of the Jan. 7, 2025, catastrophes, and points out multiple shortcomings in governmental planning and response.

The findings released Friday by the UL Research Institutes' Fire Safety Research Institute confirm key reporting by The Times, particularly about how a historically Black neighborhood where the majority of fire victims died received delayed evacuation alerts, and how the Los Angeles Fire

Department neglected signs that a Jan. 1 fire in Pacific Palisades — which later erupted into the Palisades fire — was still smoldering after the department initially contained it.

The 724-page report describes a deluge of chaos and poor communication that made evacuations, rescues and firefighting more challenging amid conditions that were already exceptionally dangerous and volatile.

In the Eaton fire, reports of an ember-storm seen by paramedics in west Altadena never reached incident commanders, the assessment found. Meanwhile, the L.A. County Fire Department — the agency at the helm of the incident — failed to formally organize evacuation operations within the command. Once reports of fire in west Altadena finally reached commanders, it took over an hour to order evacuations.

In Pacific Palisades, the LAFD failed to act on multiple warnings that the Lachman fire was still smoldering. The investigation found no evidence the Fire Department monitored the burn area as critical fire weather approached. Topanga State Park, where part of the Jan. 1 fire burned, had failed to consult fire agencies when creating its wildfire plan. [See Report, A9]

Where to find top pay by major

These are the five most popular majors at California colleges: business administration, psychology, sociology, communications and registered nursing. And where you go to college to pursue those majors can make a big difference in future earnings, according to an analysis of federal data.

During the fall college application season, as high school seniors compile lists of prospective campuses and make initial decisions about majors, evaluating the future payoff of a degree can weigh into decisions at a time when students and families are increasingly questioning the value of higher education, college advisors say.

Data reveal which colleges yield highest earnings for the five most popular degrees in California

By ANDREW KHOURI

Several of the state's most selective public and private universities that offer popular majors — including UC Berkeley, UCLA and USC — tend to top the list of students who go on to earn the highest salaries. Colleges with lower earnings can reflect regional economic differences while offering quality programs.

Also notable is that colleges within the California State University system offer a more affordable education, often without the need for student loans — and unlike other majors, top-earning graduates in registered nursing tend to graduate from CSU. [See Earnings, A6]

Sewage plant braces for El Niño

L.A.'s aging Hyperion facility, which suffered a spill in 2021, faces growing storm risks.

By SANDRA McDONALD

On the shores of Playa del Rey sits L.A.'s last line of defense against sewage streaming into the Santa Monica Bay — and a jacked El Niño this winter threatens to be more than a match for it.

Built in 1950, the Hyperion Water Reclamation Plant handles roughly 95% of the city's sewage on any given day — up to 800 million gallons of effluent from toilets, washing machines, sinks, industrial operations and more.

Storms can overwhelm the aging facility, which suffered an equipment breakdown in 2021 that led to a massive amount of raw sewage gushing into the Santa Monica Bay. Los Angeles officials are bracing for more trouble if the forecasted “super” El Niño brings heavy rains and flooding.

“We have done our best; a great job of maintaining it,” Joone Kim-Lopez, general manager of Los Angeles Sanitation and Environment, or LASAN, told the L.A. City Council recently. “But as with anything, this infrastructure needs attention.”

L.A.'s stormwater and wastewater systems are separate, but when it rains, water seeps into the ground and can sneak into the cracks of aging wastewater pipes, said Tracy Quinn, chief executive of environmental group Heal the Bay.

This is how underground pipes can burst during heavy rains — or worse, how large wastewater plants like Hyperion can be overloaded and potentially spill into the [See Hyperion, A9]



VIKTORIA PEZZEI For The Times

FESTIVALGOERS from Zorneding, a village east of Munich, Germany, stand on benches as they drink up.

Raise a nonalcoholic pint at Oktoberfest

Beer without the buzz prominent at German celebration. Some even enjoy the taste.

By ERIK KIRSCHBAUM

MUNICH, Germany — Can you have a smashing time at Oktoberfest without getting smashed yourself? Increasingly, the answer appears to be “jawohl.”

A global shift toward nonalcoholic drinks — driven by greater health consciousness from California to Cologne and beyond — has reached even the world's biggest celebration of beer.

Not long ago, ordering a nonalcoholic beer at Oktoberfest could draw puzzled looks. Or disdain. But now Oktoberfest is a proving ground for one of the most

profound changes sweeping the global drinks industry as more consumers cut alcohol from their lives.

“When I was growing up and coming here about 20 years ago, if someone ordered a nonalcoholic beer, everyone would look at you and say, ‘What’s wrong with you?’ or ‘Oh, you must be the designated driver,’” said Joerg Biebernick, chief executive of the Paulaner Brewery Group, one of Germany's largest brewers. “But now it's totally socially acceptable if you want to drink beer without alcohol.”

In the tents erected in Munich for Oktoberfest, the atmosphere can be intoxicating enough without the alcohol. Brass bands pound out songs and pop anthems with thumping beats such as Neil Diamond's “Sweet Caroline” and Robbie Williams’ [See Oktoberfest, A3]

Fatal copter crash shows risk of Catalina medical transport

By FEDOR ZARKHIN, RICHARD WINTON AND HANNAH FRY

When Catalina Romero arrived at Catalina Island's tiny emergency room this week with a severe allergic reaction, officials decided she needed medical attention on the mainland.

So they called a medical evacuation helicopter out of Oceanside. For residents of Avalon and the other Catalina communities, helicopters are part of life when emergencies and unexpected events require services the island doesn't provide.

But just moments after

takeoff, the helicopter crashed into the ocean near Pebbly Beach.

Romero, the pilot and medevac nurse Jessica Devries, 48, who were on board, were killed. The pilot's name has not been publicly released. Romero's eldest son and another passenger were injured and remain in the hospital.

As federal investigators try to determine the cause of the crash, island residents are mourning the dead and confronting the trade-offs of life so isolated from the rest of Southern California.

“It's a small community,” said Dr. Matthew Byrnes, who works at Catalina Is-

land Health. “The level of tragedy is so profound that you feel it to the core of your soul. And everybody feels the same thing.”

Dozens of flights to and from Catalina Island have crashed over the years, with pilots saying the airport poses its share of challenges. But Avalon Mayor Pro Tem Michael Ponce said most crashes involve sightseeing helicopters and private planes generally unfamiliar with the island's unique landscape and runway, officials say.

Accidents involving professionals like the medical chopper crew, he said, are [See Crash, A8]



ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

READY TO ROLL

Tarik Skubal will start for the Dodgers as they begin their quest for a third consecutive title in the Division Series against Atlanta. **SPORTS, B12**

Officials ‘failed’ Cornell accuser

New York Gov. Kathy Hochul appoints attorney general as special prosecutor in campus rape case. **NATION, A4**

Could tacos give Hilton a boost?

Republican gubernatorial candidate meets Gustavo Arellano and the columnist's dad for lunch. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Very hot. L.A. basin: 103/77. **B8**

